



dia.com/downloads/.

Perhaps the first name that one thinks of when going online to play a game is Yahoo! Games. It provides many Java-based single and multiplayer games. If you are playing a multiplayer game, you can choose a room to play in. After you have joined a room, you can join an existing game, create your own game, or just watch a game. The best part of Yahoo! is that it comes up with new games frequently—addictive games that are easy to learn. The bad part is that not all games are free. Keep an eye out for the words ‘All-Star’, these require you to pay Yahoo! a small fee to play. It’s also hard to figure out which games are single player and which are multiplayer.

Another thing to keep an eye out for is the attitudes of players. Yahoo! has a ranking system: when you first join, you are given the rank of ‘Provisional player’. Based on your performance in successive attempts, this ranking improves. The problem is that higher ranked players tend to treat a Provisional player as an amateur; they might even refuse to play. If this happens, simply ignore them and find other players and games to join.

MSN Gaming Zone (www.zone.com) from Microsoft offers 71 free single and multiplayer games. The games are designed well, and you may need to load some software before you can play. When you get the software install security warning, insure that it’s from Microsoft, click Yes, and you’re ready to play. Though there are paid games available, the free games section is clearly demarcated on the home page. However, you will have to endure many advertisements, and ensure that you click on the correct link to start playing. Also, remember that there might be problems if you use a browser other than Internet Explorer 5 and above.

Playsite (www.playsite.com) offers many interesting and addictive Java-based single and multiplayer games. The emphasis of this site is on winning virtual cash by playing games. When you register as a ‘Free player’, you’re given 500 ‘Playing bucks’.

Depending on whether you lose or win, playing bucks are added or subtracted from your account. This adds the feel of playing with real money, and can get quite addictive. You can keep asking for more until your request total up to 500 playing bucks. All the games are conveniently arranged in categories—Card Games, Billiards, Puzzles, Word Games, Board Games, etc.

Miniclip (www.miniclip.com) features around 150 free Macromedia Flash and Shockwave games, and more games are added frequently. You will find many unique games here such as Snowboarder, Golf, Trial Bike, Table Tennis and Couronne. The only drawback is that since they’re all based on Flash or Shockwave, the games might take a little long to load, especially if you’re on a dial-up connection. Some games are totally free, while others are demo versions of paid games. If you are playing a demo version, you can only play each game for 15 minutes a day.

SkyLords found at www.skylords.com, is a massive multiplayer strategy game, which is played using only your browser, totally free! It includes many interesting features such as diplomacy, trading, piracy, espionage, space battles, custom spaceship model designing and clan warfare. This server can support thousands of players at a time, and each round lasts a month—starting on the first of every month, but you can join in anytime. When you signup, you have to undergo a training session to learn how the game works. This game is recommended for those who love strategy games. Another game similar to SkyLords is Fate Lords (www.fatelords.com), and they’re many more online. To learn more about these MMOGs (Massive Multiplayer Online Games), go to MassMOG (www.massmog.com), a site dedicated to gaming and development news, articles and a discussion forum.

Everything but

Though browser-based games don’t require fast connections and servers, software-



based games such as the *Quake* series do. Even if you have a fast connection, but use a slow server, or use one that’s just too far away from you, be prepared for jerky frame rates and a thoroughly uninspiring gaming experience. When playing software-based games online, remember the golden rule of Ping. The ping command is your friend, and will help you have a better gaming experience. The ping application is used to verify the existence of an IP address.

